Marco Lo Faso

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USC Dornsife
Dana and David Dornsife
College of Letters, Arts and Sciences
Department of Economics

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Placement Director: Vittorio Bassi, vbassi@usc.edu
Placement Director: Michael Droste, droste@usc.edu
Placement Administrator: Annie Le, anniele@usc.edu

Education

University of Southern California
Ph.D. Economics (expected) 2027
Harvard University
Visiting Ph.D. Student, Department of Economics 2025–2026
Bocconi University
M.Sc. Public Policy and Political Economy 2019
B.Sc. Economics 2016

Fields

Political Economy, Spatial Economics, Applied Microeconomics

References

Thomas Chaney (Chair)	Augustin Bergeron	Jeff Weaver
USC Economics	Harvard Economics	USC Economics
thomas.chaney@usc.edu	abergeron@fas.harvard.edu	jbweaver@usc.edu

Job Market Paper

Where Do Protests Win or Lose Votes? Exposure and Participation in the George Floyd Movement

This paper asks how protests affect voting in the neighborhoods where they take place and in those where their participants live. In the 2020 George Floyd movement, I find that two effects coexist and pull in opposite directions: neighborhoods near protest sites shifted toward the Republican candidate—a backlash—while those where participants lived shifted toward the Democratic candidate—a mobilization. To separate them, I combine 7,920 geocoded protest events with mobile phone location data and measure for each block group in American metropolitan areas its exposure to nearby protests and its residents' participation. I then exploit differences in exposure and participation across block groups within the same zip code to estimate the effect of each on the change in vote shares between the 2016 and 2020 presidential elections. The backlash decays with distance and its point estimates are larger near violent protests, while the mobilization comes mostly from participation in nonviolent protests. Both results hold in a difference-in-differences design that follows the same neighborhoods across the presidential elections from 2012 to 2024, with no detectable pre-trend before the protests. Taken at face value, my estimates imply that participation moved about 137,000 votes toward the Democrats across the sample, while exposure within three kilometers of protest sites cost them about 87,000; adding the effect of exposure farther away, the net is not distinguishable from zero.

Work in Progress

Congregations and the Market for Urban Floor Space: Evidence from São Paulo
The Urban Constraints on Political Mobilization: Evidence from American Cities
The Labor Market Returns to Religious Networks: Evidence from Uganda (with Aruj Shukla)

Awards

Dean's Dissertation Completion Fellowship, USC — $21,218	2026–2027
Lusk Center for Real Estate Research Award, USC — $13,500	2026
Lusk Center for Real Estate Research Award, USC — $15,000	2025
Dan James Fellowship, USC — $40,000	2024–2025
Summer Research Award (x4), USC — $4,000 each	2023–2026

Employment

European Central Bank, Frankfurt, Research Intern	2019
European Commission, Brussels, Economic Analyst	2017–2018

Research Positions

Research Assistant to Augustin Bergeron, USC	2023
Research Assistant to Ruben Durante, Pompeu Fabra University	2020–2021
Research Assistant to Vincenzo Galasso, Bocconi University	2019–2020

Teaching

Teaching Assistant, University of Southern California Fall 2022–Spring 2024
- *Introduction to Econometrics* (ECON 318), undergraduate
- *Political Economy and Economic Development* (ECON 436), undergraduate
- *Intermediate Macroeconomics* (ECON 305), undergraduate
- *Macroeconomic Analysis and Policy* (ECON 501), master

Teaching Assistant, Bocconi University 2019–2020
- *Welfare and Politics*, master
- *Economics of European Integration*, master
- *Political Economics*, undergraduate
- *European Economic Policy*, undergraduate

Presentations

2026 (scheduled): SOCAE, UC Santa Barbara; UCI–UCLA–USC Workshop on Urban and Real Estate Economics, USC; ESI Brown Bag, Chapman University
2026: USC Development Seminar, Harvard Graduate Student Workshop in Political Economy
2023–2026: USC Applied Micro Reading Group

Summer Schools

Summer School in the Economics of Migration, UC Davis	2024
ACES Summer School in Political Economy, UC Berkeley	2023

Academic Service

Co-organizer, Southern California Graduate Conference in Applied Economics
University of Southern California 2023

Research Grants

Weiss Fund Research Grant — $5,000 2023–2024

Software Skills

Python, R, Stata, MATLAB

Languages

Italian (native), English (fluent)

Citizenship

Italian (US F-1 visa)